



SLUGLORD, LORD OF SLUGS

A one-shot for 3–5 characters of 5th to 7th level. It does not chase. It does not need to.

THE VALLEY OF GRUENMULDE

No one in the valley remembers when Sluglord was small. The temple ledgers record him only as The Creeping Famine; the children call him what he is. The druids teach that every slug you have ever salted dreams of him, and that he dreams back. The elders say he is a punishment, though they argue pleasantly about for what.

The Truth (DM Only). Eleven years ago, Mayor Pfaffenkraut lost the Grand Fair to a rival cabbage and buried the shame-crowned loser behind the temple, in the one compost heap the priests never got around to consecrating. Something down there accepted the offering. Something down there has been growing ever since. The mayor knows. The mayor has always known. He will take it to his grave, which may be soon and may be extremely slow-moving.

THE SITUATION

The Numbers. Sluglord has crested Hangman Hill, three miles east. His speed is five feet per round, every round, without rest. A hired ranger has done the arithmetic and quit. Arrival: three days, at dawn. He is heading — the scouts triple-checked — directly for the village granary, the cabbage fields, and the brewery, in what the priests grimly call "the correct order of worship."

The Ask. The village council will beg the party to save Gruenmulde. They can offer 200 gp, lifetime bread, and — if pressed in this exact order — the contents of the salt cellar, the contents of the beer cellar, and the mayors cabbage. The mayor is not present when this list is read aloud.

RUMORS AT THE WEEPING KEG (d6)

1. "He ate a paladin once. Armor and all. The armor took a week." (True.)
2. "Salt only makes him angry." (False. Salt makes him dead, eventually, in bulk.)
3. "He can smell a champion cabbage from nine miles." (True. The mayor pales.)
4. "He was summoned by the next village over. Out of spite." (False, but it starts a fistfight.)
5. "If it rains, we are all dead." (Essentially true. See Rain-Blessed.)
6. "Old Muttchen the druid talks to him." (True. He does not listen. He is, she admits, "not a listener.")



THE LORD HIMSELF

Gargantuan Monstrosity (Unkillable Nuisance), Unaligned

Armor Class 9 (he is a slug)

Hit Points 310 (23d20 + 69)

Speed 5 ft. (see It Does Not Hurry)

STR 24 (+7) DEX 1 (-5) CON 17 (+3)

INT 1 (-5) WIS 10 (+0) CHA 4 (-3)

Damage Vulnerabilities salt (see Salt of the Earth)

Damage Resistances bludgeoning, piercing

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, prone, exhaustion

Senses blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 10

Languages — (Old Muttchen disagrees)

Challenge 8 (3,900 XP) · Proficiency +3

TRAITS

It Does Not Hurry. Sluglords speed is always 5 feet. No effect can increase or reduce it, and he never takes the Dash action. He always knows the direction of the nearest large concentration of crops, livestock, or ale. He moves toward it. Always.

Regeneration. Sluglord regains 20 hit points at the start of his turn. If he took fire or salt damage since his last turn, this trait does not function.

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If Sluglord fails a saving throw, he can choose to succeed instead. He is simply too thick.

Salt of the Earth. Salt burns Sluglord like holy fire. A thrown pound deals 2d4 damage; a 25-lb. sack deals 5d8; a full cartload deals 12d8 (DC 12 Dexterity check to tip it in time). He is vulnerable to this damage, and it bypasses Regeneration.

Slime Wake. Ground Sluglord moves through is coated in adhesive slime for 24 hours and is difficult terrain. A creature that ends its turn there must succeed on a DC 14 Strength saving throw or be restrained (escape DC 14).

Rain-Blessed. While it is raining, Sluglords speed becomes 10 feet — nothing can prevent this — and his Regeneration increases to 30.

ACTIONS

Multiaattack. Sluglord makes two Antennae Sweep attacks.

Antennae Sweep. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 15 ft., one target. Hit: 18 (2d10 + 7) bludgeoning damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone into the slime.

Radula Grind. One creature restrained or prone within 10 ft. is rasped by ten thousand tiny teeth: 25 (4d8 + 7) slashing damage. The sound is unforgettable.

Engulf (Recharge 5-6). Sluglord moves up to his speed (all 5 feet of it) and can enter the spaces of Large or smaller creatures. Each must succeed on a DC 15 Dexterity saving throw or be engulfed: restrained, blinded, and taking 14 (4d6) acid damage at the start of each of Sluglords turns. A creature can see Engulf coming from a very long way off. This does not always help. Escape: DC 15 Strength; the creature emerges prone, in slime.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS (2/Round)

Ripple. The slime tightens. One restrained creature is dragged 10 feet closer.

Secrete. Slime bursts in a 10-foot radius around a point on Sluglord; the area becomes Slime Wake terrain.

Ponderous Menace. Sluglord moves 5 feet. By the third day, this is genuinely frightening.



THE SLOW SIEGE

Sluglord is not a monster encounter. Sluglord is a deadline.

DAY ONE — THE NEWS

Dawn. Refugees arrive from the flattened farmstead. Nobody died; they walked away at a comfortable stroll, which somehow makes it worse. Give the party the map, the distance, and the speed. Watch them do the math. That moment is the adventure.

The Council. Mayor Odo Pfaffenkraut (pompous, guilt-ridden, smells faintly of compost when nervous) opens the floor. Berta "Two-Kegs" Immergruen, innkeeper of the Weeping Keg, proposes evacuation of "the important barrels." Elmo Ruskin, salt merchant, says nothing and smiles at his ledger. Old Muttchen Salbei, druid, suggests everyone simply apologize to him. She is not specific about how.

DAY TWO — THE PRICE

Ruskins Bargain. Fifty times market price for the salt cellar, payable in coin or "considerations." Persuasion DC 16, Intimidation DC 14 (he folds instantly and remembers forever), or theft — he counts his sacks twice a day, at breakfast and at spite.

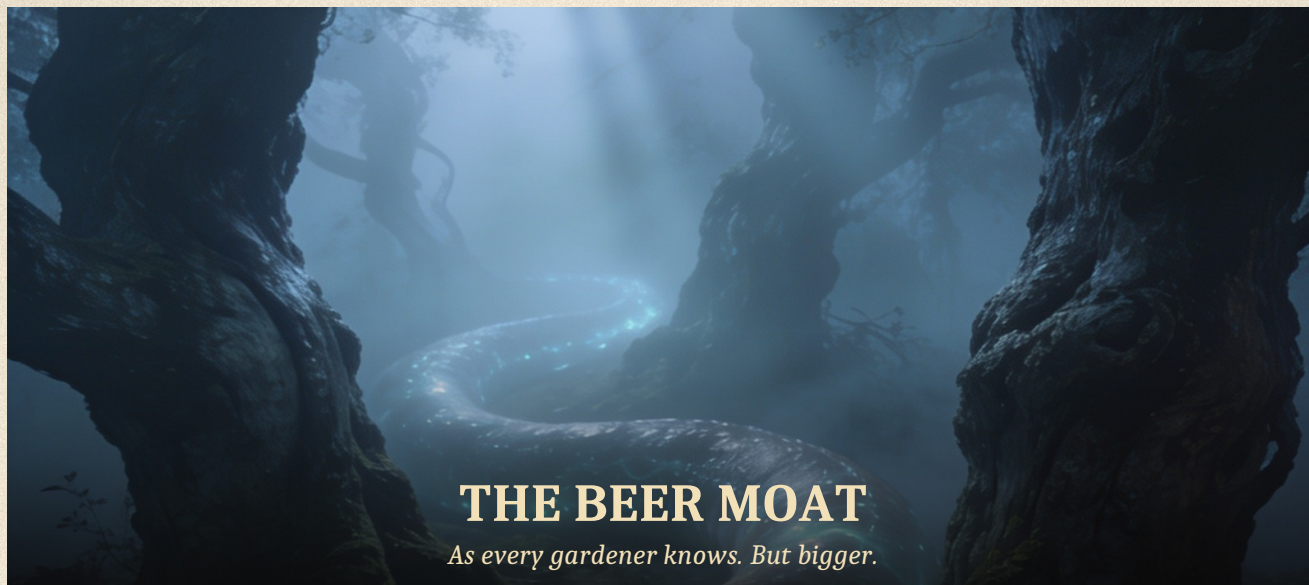
The Cabbage Question. Any plan involving lures leads to Der Gruene Kaiser, the mayors thrice-champion cabbage, kept under lock, guard, and a small devotional candle. The mayor would sooner offer the party his firstborn, and says so, in front of his firstborn.

The Sky Darkens. If the party has wasted a day, storm clouds build. It rains on Day Three: speed doubled, arrival twelve hours early, at night, glistening.

DAY THREE — ARRIVAL

The Fight, if it comes. Sluglord crests the last hill at dawn (or midnight, in rain). Prepared parties fight a siege: salt lines, fire trenches, fallback positions, and one villager who refuses to leave the granary out of principle. Unprepared parties learn what 310 hit points and Regeneration 20 feel like at five feet per round.

DM note: never joke about Sluglord at the table. Describe the smell, the sound of the radula, the slow patient wet weight of him. The players will supply the laughter — and around Day Two, they will stop. That is where the good sessions live.



THE BEER MOAT

As every gardener knows. But bigger.

THE NO-COMBAT PATH

Sluglord cannot be reasoned with, but he can be tempted. A moat of ale across his path will draw him in — and a slug that drinks a villages worth of beer stops being anyones problem for a season. Run it as a skill challenge: six successes before three failures, across the three days.

Phase One — Convince the Village. Every barrel. All of it. Berta weeps openly, then rallies, then confesses under pressure that she has watered the beer for years — which, the party may realize, means there is MORE of it. Persuasion DC 14; advantage if the party pledges coin or first pick of next years brew.

Phase Two — Dig. A trench sixty feet long, ten wide, five deep, across his exact path (it never changes; that is the one mercy). Group Athletics DC 13 each morning, aided by every able villager. Each failure costs half a day.

Phase Three — The Lure. Survival or Nature DC 14 to lay a scent trail to the moat — best done with Der Gruene Kaiser dragged on a rope. The mayor will not surrender the cabbage while conscious. Handle this however your table handles things.

OUTCOMES

Full Success. Sluglord slides into the moat, drinks, shudders with what can only be called joy, and sleeps for a season. The village founds a festival on the spot — the Feast of the Sleeping Lord — at which the party drinks free, forever, of whatever Berta is calling beer that year.

Partial Success. Sluglord is drunk: speed 0 for one hour, attacks against him have advantage, and he loses Legendary Resistance. The village calls this variant Blackout Sluglord. Kill him while he snores — if your table can live with that. Old Muttchen will not attend the festival.

Failure. The village evacuates. Sluglord eats Gruenmulde at his own pace over four days, including the temple, the brewery, and — the mayor watching from the ridge — Der Gruene Kaiser. Survivors agree the sound was the worst part.

SPOILS

Slime of Endless Adhesion (3 uses). A paste; each use bonds two objects for 24 hours. Smells exactly how you fear.

Radula Fragment. A dagger of pale chitin, +1d4 acid damage on hit. It whispers, very faintly, of cabbage.

The Antenna. A trophy. No mechanical benefit. Enormous social benefit in any tavern in the valley.

Epilogue, full success: eleven months later, a letter reaches the party. The festival was a triumph, the mayor has retired, and Bertas daughter reports that from the moat, on quiet nights, comes a sound she can only describe as contented. The village has voted, narrowly, not to check.